

MY400 MY4IR – Seminar W2 – From research topics to research questions

(W1 lecture topic)

Please use this document to prepare for the seminar – it will essentially form a topic guide for our discussions (it is there to guide us, but we can deviate from it according to the interests of the group)

Essential Reading

Before attending the seminar, please read:

- The 'Course information' document on the Moodle page
- The Powerpoint slides "How to read a paper", available under this week's section
- Knopf, J. W. (2006). Doing a literature review. *PS: Political Science & Politics*, 39(1), 127-132.
- Sandberg, Jörgen, and Mats Alvesson. "Ways of Constructing Research Questions: Gap-Spotting or Problematization?" *Organization* 18, no. 1 (January 15, 2011): 23-44.
- Day, C. & Koivu, K.L. (2019). Finding the Question: A Puzzle-Based Approach to the Logic of Discovery. *Journal of Political Science Education*, 15(3), 377-386.

Seminar activity #1 – Questions about the course

To start, please take the opportunity to ask your seminar teacher if any aspect of the course is unclear to you. Make sure you know the contact hours, where to find the reading and seminar activities for each week, what the assessments are and when they happen. If anything seems mysterious, please don't be shy to ask.

Seminar activity #2 – Discussion on reading as a research practice, and literature reviews

Reading is a core activity of research. Through reading other people's research:

- We learn what has been done before, which is fundamental to cumulative knowledge;
- We acquire language to speak about it, such as concepts;
- We expand our imagination about what it is possible to do in relation to our topic of interest or the phenomenon we want to investigate;
- We become more critical about what looks convincing and what does not;
- We acquire models and ideas that we can use as examples or inspiration in our own research (which is different from plagiarism!).

For all these reasons, we use reading and discussing readings as a core part of our course pedagogy. The slides on 'How to read a paper' on the Moodle page present a classic approach to reading. Students tend to come to this course with a variety of practices and perspectives on how to read. Now is a great time to share perspectives and benefit from each other's wisdom!

We'll discuss the following questions, as well as any others you'd like to raise:

- Is your experience/practice of reading academic articles similar to the strategies presented in the slides? If not, how do your habits differ (and what are their pros and cons)?
- What do your experience as your main challenges in reading academic articles?
- Have you tried using AI applications to aid your reading? What has been your experience of that (any pros, any cons)?
- What system do you have (if any!) for note-taking, particularly when preparing to write a literature review?

- What are the purposes of a literature review (both according to Knopf, and according to you)?
- What do you experience as your main challenges in writing a literature review?
- How might AI applications help or hinder in writing a literature review? What are the potential pros and cons?

Seminar activity #3 – Discussion on identifying a research question: Sandberg & Alvesson (2011) and Day & Koivu (2019)

The Sandberg & Alvesson paper is an empirical article with a theoretical argument; the Day & Koivu paper is a much shorter note or comment-type piece. So, at the risk of being slightly too ‘meta’, we can use Sandberg & Alvesson as a vehicle for nice warm-up activity for critiquing published papers.

Use the questions below to help you during your reading, and we will use (some of) them as a starting point for our seminar discussion. As well as the pointers below, do note down and questions or thoughts that you'd like to raise.

Starting with the Sandberg & Alvesson paper:

1. Background/literature review
 - a. How do the authors motivate their own paper via recourse to the literature?
 - b. How do they distinguish the purpose of their study from other previous work in this area?
2. Research questions and design
 - c. What are the stated research questions guiding this paper?
 - d. Can you suggest narrower versions of the authors' research questions? Based on the guidelines provided in the lecture, formulate a couple of research questions that would align with the research design and announced objectives of this article.
3. Outcomes of the study
 - e. What types of research questions do authors identify? How is their conceptualisation of these research question construction approaches informed by their own empirical work?
 - f. Do you find the distinction the authors make convincing? Why/why not?
4. Limitations and further research
 - g. Are there other ways of motivating research questions you can think of that the authors do not attend to? Following how the authors name the approaches to gap-spotting they identify, how would you name them?
 - h. Now bringing in the Day & Koivu paper – what is the connection (and difference) between a gap and a puzzle?
5. Pick a type of gap and a type of puzzle (identified by you or the authors) and write a template sentence for each in the way that you could use it in the future in your assignment. This is hypothetically and just to develop your research design imagination and writing skills - you are not expected to know what the question motivation strategy of your assignment will be at this stage). For example, a template sentence for “confusion spotting” can look like: “While the literature has clearly demonstrated the relevance of studying [x], the mechanism and conditions under which this process occurs remains unclear”. Which approach do you find the most helpful, given your research interests? NB your interests may be empirically focused, theoretically focused, rooted in one or more academic disciplines, well-defined in your mind or vague and initial – any of these starting points are fine – the important thing is to get a conversation going.

